BI even after this meeting, but under a false name.[36] Evidently, there were some merchants hedging their bets. From the outset, there were hypocrites who waxed eloquent on Swadeshi but shipped cargo on BI vessels.[37])

We see a clear pattern in this incident: the enthusiasm of the Swadeshi volunteers, the easy access that the European firm had to the police and administration which were ever ready to jump to safeguard BI's interests and VOC's sagacity in deftly handling the situation without escalating it.

The rising business of the Swadeshi company hit BI hard. In his application to the high court for transfer of the security cases from the district magistrate, VOC stated that his campaign had caused heavy loss to European merchants and, as a result, they instituted criminal cases against several employees of SSNCo right from 1906. From the beginning of 1908, VOC focused on getting all merchants to forsake BI and had succeeded by the end of February: the entire cargo from Tuticorin to Colombo was being moved exclusively by the Swadeshi ships.[38]

VOC's efforts to induct some recalcitrant traders to the Swadeshi company needs recounting here. The business of SSNCo was booming because of hectic Swadeshi activity and VOC wanted to mop up all the business. On 29 February, many cattle-shippers and merchants assembled at the home of M.N. Gonsalves along with VOC. The agenda was to persuade the few remaining merchants still shipping through BI's steamers to switch to SSNCo. Details of this meeting emerge from the security proceedings that Ashe initiated against Swadeshi lawyers after VOC's arrest to prevent them from supporting the Swadeshi movement. The interrogation by Ashe was reported widely in the press. Two of VOC's associates, K.R. Venkatarama Aiyar and P.L. Vengu Aiyar, both lawyers, were also present apart from a handful of others. Kaithan Villavarayar, a boat contractor for BI, was at first prevented from entering the house by VOC's men. The meeting went on late, an indication that the discussion was charged if not acrimonious. The allegation of the prosecution witnesses was that VOC bullied the merchants into transporting cargo on the Swadeshi steamers. While Anthony Savarimuthu Rodriguez, S.K. Marakayar (names that we will recall that figured as initial promoters of the company) and Mathur